



GET BUSY LIVING, OR GET BUSY DYING

THE SHAWSHANK REDEMPTION / 1994

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Drama

DIRECTOR

Frank Darabont

WRITERS

**Frank Darabont
(screenplay); Stephen
King (short story)**

STARS

**Tim Robbins, Morgan
Freeman, Bob Gunton**

BEFORE

1979 *Escape from Alcatraz* tells the true story of a breakout from prison.

1983 *The Woman in the Room* is Darabont's first movie, also based on a Stephen King story.

AFTER

1995 Tim Robbins directs *Dead Man Walking*, the story of a man on death row.

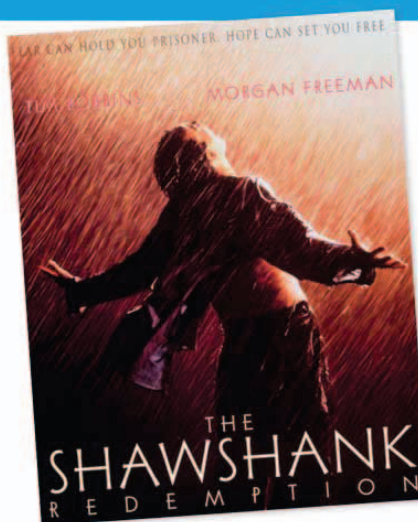
1999 Darabont films King's *The Green Mile*, another prison drama, set in the 1930s.

A movie that deals with the triumph of the human spirit over adversity has a delicate line to tread. Misjudge the balance between dignity and suffering and the triumph will either feel hollow or not worth the ordeal, for protagonist and audience alike.

In *The Shawshank Redemption*, with its story of a man who is sentenced to life in a prison run by a corrupt warden, director Frank Darabont achieves the perfect balance. The movie emphasizes humanity over brutality, and it has become one of the most popular movies ever made about the power of self-belief.

Unconventional prisoner

In its lead character, Andy Dufresne (Tim Robbins), the movie subverts the tough-guy protagonist of previous prison dramas such as *Cool Hand Luke* (1967) or *Escape from Alcatraz* (1979). A former banker who is convicted of murdering his wife and her lover in



The movie's initially low returns at the box office were rapidly offset by seven Oscar nominations and lasting popularity with the public.

1947, Andy is a sensitive, thoughtful man. His strength is not physical; it derives from his belief in the individual's inviolate right to justice and humane treatment, which allows him to maintain his integrity even when his situation seems hopeless.

Although Andy is trapped in a system that seeks to crush him and institutionalize him, the audience has the impression that he is freer than many of those at liberty. He never loses hope that life can get better, whether he is campaigning for an improved prison library or cutting a deal with one of the most brutal guards to get his fellow jailbirds a beer after a day's labor.